

The Dhāraṇī Called Surūpa

Surūpa-nāma-dhāraṇī · Toh 540 · Derge Kangyur

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The Dhāraṇī Called Surūpa, known in Sanskrit as the Surūpa-nāma-dhāraṇī and in Tibetan as Su rū pa zhes bya ba'i gzungs, is a short ritual dhāraṇī text concerned with the benefits conferred by reciting a sacred mantra formula, including the beautification of the body and the gladdening of the mind. The text centers on a dhāraṇī addressed to the tathāgata Surūpa and provides practical instructions for its use, particularly the recitation of the mantra seven times over food mixed with water as an offering to hungry ghosts, suggesting a compassionate aim of relieving the suffering of beings in lower states of existence. It is Toh 540 in the Kangyur, belonging to the general class of dhāraṇī literature, and it appears alongside the preceding dhāraṇī of the Lotus Eyes of the Noble One, indicating it forms part of a broader collection of such ritual and apotropaic texts within the canon.

The body will become beautiful. The mind will become joyful. This concludes the dhāraṇī called "The Lotus Eyes of the Noble One."

In the language of India: Surūpa-nāma-dhāraṇī. In the Tibetan language: the dhāraṇī called Surūpa.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Namas surūpāya, tathāgatāya, arhate samyaksambuddhāya. Tadyathā: om suru suru, prasuru prasuru, tara tara, bhara bhara, sambhara sambhara, smara smara, santarpaya santarpaya, sarvapretānām svāhā.

With this dhāraṇī, recite it seven times over food mixed with water, then snap the fingers of the left hand three times, and in a secluded place offer it to all the hungry ghosts. One should also pronounce these words: "Let those who are searching for an opening, those who are watching for an opportunity, be at ease. To all hungry ghosts dwelling throughout every world-realm, I give this food." This offering should be made before one has eaten one's own meal.

In this way, to every hungry ghost there will be given a great measure of food each individually. If this is done, from life to life one will never be born in lowly circumstances. One will not be born poor. One will come to have great strength, beauty, a pleasing appearance, wealth, and great enjoyment of resources. One will be long-lived and free from illness, and will swiftly attain

unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. After death, one will be reborn in the world-realm of Sukhāvatī. This concludes the dhāraṇī called Surūpa.

Translator's Notes

- The phrase rendered "snap the fingers" translates a Tibetan term for making a snapping sound with the fingers, specifically described as a gesture of summoning or dispersing; the left hand is specified in the original, which is ritually significant in the preta-feeding context.

The passage opens mid-sentence ("The body will become beautiful. The mind will become joyful.") because it is the tail end of the preceding dhāraṇī text, the Padmanetra dhāraṇī, whose benefits were being enumerated. This is noted for context but does not affect the translation.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.